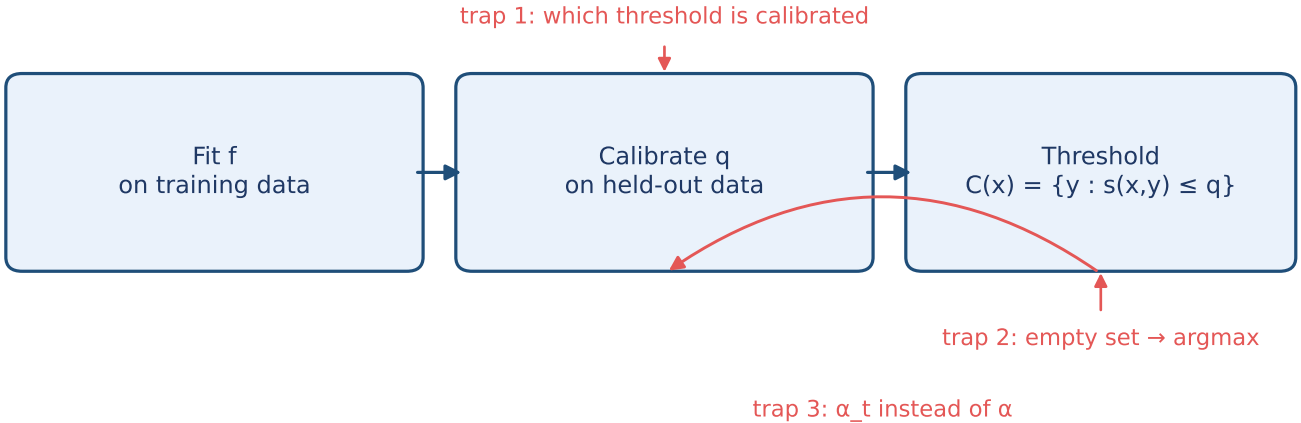

the same three stages in every method; the guarantee comes from the middle one